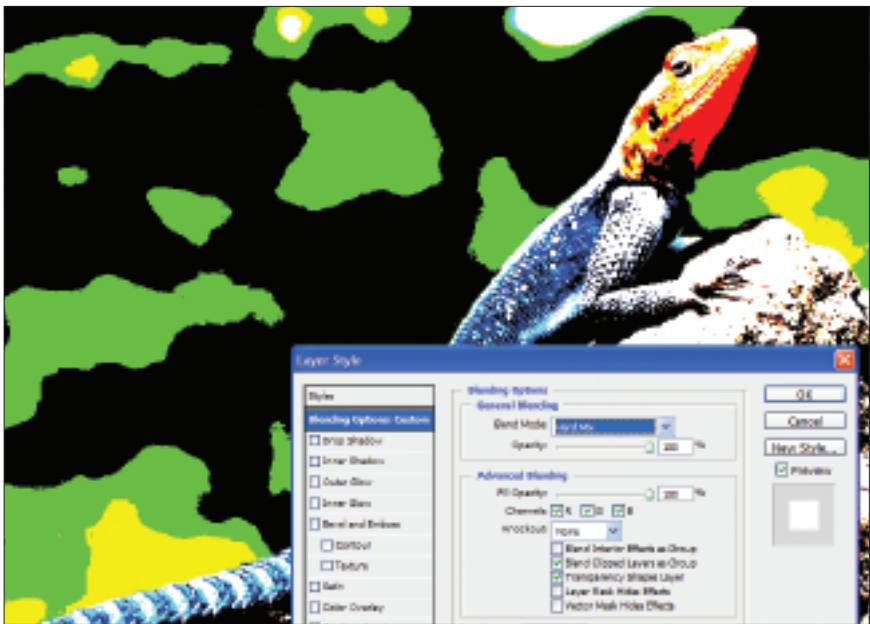




The new Hard Mix blending option

ence to the image if both the layers are the same unaltered image. The Lighter Color blending mode does the exact opposite, by displaying the lighter of two possible colours. This mode will show no difference if both the layers are the same. The Hard Mix option is an interesting new feature. The blending adds the color components on the channels, giving a display colour of 255 if the colours add up to more than 255, and 0 if they don't.

Content Aware Scaling

One of the best features of CS4 is content aware scaling. This is great for converting regular wallpapers to widescreen wallpapers. This feature preserves the important aspects of images while resizing them. This means that while stretching images, important elements like buildings or people don't get distorted. In this example, a picture with a width of 1850 pixels was stretched to a 3000 pixel width. The picture on the left was scaled in CS3, whereas the picture on the right was scaled in CS4 using con-



Stretching without content-aware scaling (left) and with content-aware scaling (right)

tent aware scaling. Go to Edit > Content Aware Scaling to choose this option. Normally, Photoshop does a good job of preserving the content when you rescale an image. First, select the area of the image you want preserved using the select tool. Then go to Channels (the tab next to layers) and click on save Selection as channel (the white circle in the grey square). Now go to Edit > Content Aware Scaling, and use the Protect drop down box to select the channel you just created. This is usually Alpha 1, but if you created more channels, these will be named Alpha 2, Alpha 3...

Export all Layer Comps to files

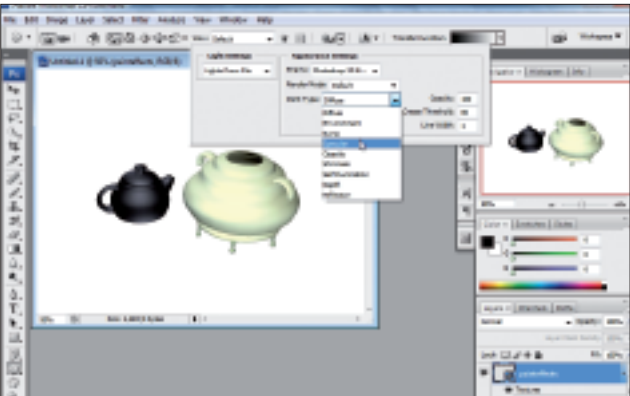
Instead of manually saving layer compositions to files, you can use a



preset script to export all existing layer compositions to files. For this procedure to work, you need to have at least one Layer Comp saved in the file. Go to File > Scripts > Layer Comp to Files. Select the output and compression settings. Then click Run. While you cannot work on more than one Layer Comp at once, you can select multiple Layer Comps to be exported. This can be done by selecting the Layer Comps instead of displaying them. When exporting, check the "selected Layer Comps Only" option.

Working with 3D Objects

Photoshop can now work with 3D objects, but just make sure that you have plenty of RAM and plenty of Scratch Disk space before attempting to do so. To open a file, simply go to File > Open and choose a 3D object. You can rotate and resize such objects using the buttons just below the traditional toolbox. You can paint directly on the 3D objects, and the filters you apply will be applied to the surface or "texture" of the 3D objects.



Working with 3d objects on Photoshop

Install missing features in CS4

Veteran users will come across a few effects and plugins that are missing in Photoshop CS4. These are extras that were included in the goodies folder of previous versions, but no included in the latest version. The missing features include commonly used features like web photo gallery maker, the texture fill and the PDF presentation maker. To fix these missing features (and more), go to <http://tinyurl.com/cs4missing> and select the platform. You will need a fairly powerful internet connection though, as this is a 40 MB download. The files have to be placed in the plugins folder.

Amarok MP3 Player

Amarok is the MP3 player of choice for most Linux users. It is simple to install and to configure, and is packed with features. Amarok is available for download from <http://amarok.kde.org>. The MP3 player will work on GNOME or any other desktop environment as long as the relevant libraries are installed. Just use the package manager to install Amarok, and you should be good to go. Note that some of the features of Amarok are particularly buggy on a few distributions such as Linux Mint and Ubuntu.

Getting started with Amarok

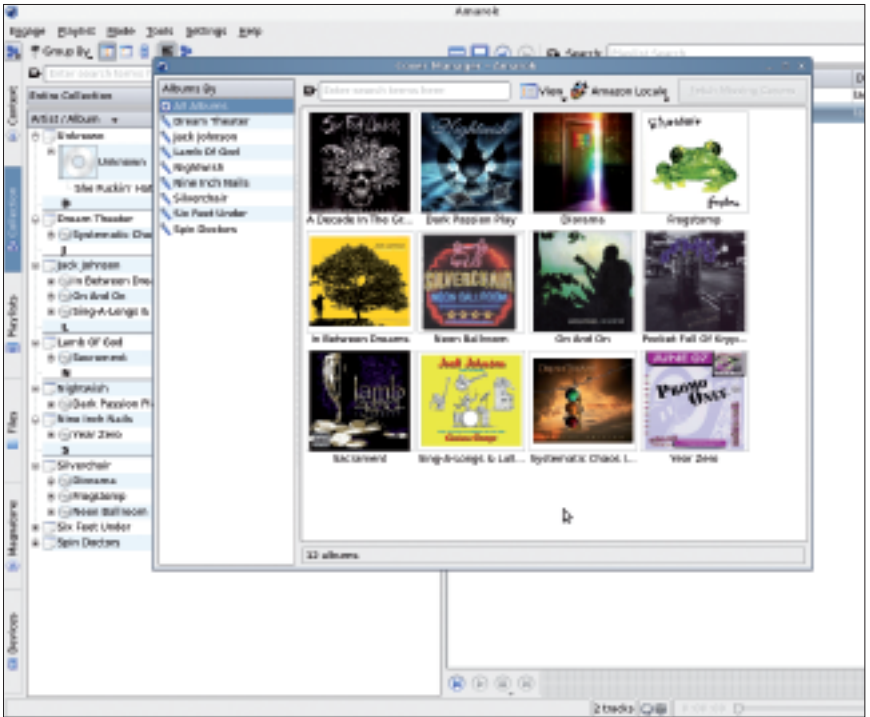
Amarok cannot start playing MP3 files the moment it is installed. The main reason for this is that the codec is propriety, and cannot be distributed for free. Before installing the codec, you will have to install an engine. Go to the package manager, and choose both the yauap and the xine engines for Amarok. Once these are installed, install the mp3 codec from www.fluendo.com. This is an online shop that "sells" MP3 codecs for no money. Finally, build your MP3 collection by pressing the Build button that appears when you start up Amarok. Choose the folder with your MP3 files, or choose multiple folders and click OK. Your music has now been imported into Amarok, and you are good to go.

Play music from last.fm

For this procedure to work, you will need an account with last.fm, so make sure you have one. To play music from last.fm, go to Engage > Play last.fm Stream > Custom station. Here, you will have to enter the name of the artist, a genre of music or a particular band of your preference. Last.fm will choose similar songs based on what you input in this box. You will then be prompted for your username and password. Next, you will be prompted to accept cookies. This is just the way last.fm works, and the songs you listen to will be metered and counted by last.fm. This keeps tracks of your statistics, as well as improves recommendations that last.fm throws your way. Right click on the track you are streaming from last.fm to love or ban the track, directly on the server.

Turn on crossfading

To turn on crossfading, go to Settings > Configure Amarok >



Looking for album art

Playback > Transition and select crossfading. Set a crossfade duration as per your preference. You can also choose to implement the crossfade on only automatic track changes or on only manual track changes.

Add album art to collection

You can automatically add album art to your entire collection. If your folders have an album art, they will be detected and shown. If there are missing album covers, Amarok can retrieve them from the Internet. This step requires a working Internet connection. Go to Tools > Cover Manager. This should show you all the artists in your collection with the relevant covers. Blank cases are shown for artists without covers. Click on Fetch missing covers to update the covers for these artists and albums. This will take a long time depending on how many covers need to be updated and the speed of your connection.

Find out the name of your song

If you have an album full of songs without IDv3 information, or just a few odd songs that have neither tagged information nor file name, you can still find out what the song is in Amarok. Right-click on one such track, and select Edit Track Information. Under the

Tags tab, select Fill-In Tags Using MusicBrainz. The program automatically searches for similar songs, and generates the content for the tags. Note that this is not hundred per cent foolproof.

Look up the lyrics and artist information

While playing a song, look to the context menu, and then go to the Lyrics tab. This should throw up a choice of two scripts for getting lyrics: Astraweb and Lyr. Choose one of the two scripts which should fetch you the lyrics of the song you are listening. This will be displayed in the window. The Artist tab in the context menu brings up artist information from Wikipedia.

Play Shoutcast radio on Amarok

Go to Playlist > Radio Streams > Shoutcast streams, to find a long list of Internet radio stations. Choose a genre, then select a particular station, after which you can choose a sub-station. Double-click, and the music should start streaming.

Work with playlist

To load an artist or an album as a playlist, right-click on the name of the album/artist and click on Load. You can also select a few songs and click on Load.